

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Sajith Wickramasekara, Founder & CEO, Benchling **Released October 17, 2025**

Jessica: Today, Carolyn and I are here with Sajith Wickramasekara, the founder and CEO of Benchling. Welcome, Sajith.
[\(00:00:00\)](#)

Carolynn: Nice to see you.
[\(00:00:08\)](#)

Sajith: Nice to see you too. Thanks for having me.
[\(00:00:09\)](#)

Jessica: We're delighted to see you. You went through Y Combinator summer twenty twelve. It's a long time ago. We know way back.
[\(00:00:11\)](#)

Sajith: Thirteen years.
[\(00:00:18\)](#)

Jessica: Thirteen years ago, you founded this company. And this is a special a special episode of the Social Radars. We are here at the Y Combinator Founder Mode Retreat, and we're surrounded by all these amazing founders. And we're trying to explore the idea of what is founder mode because we know that founder mode, by definition, is doing things as a founder CEO that a hired CEO couldn't or wouldn't do. But we don't know what that is in practice.
[\(00:00:19\)](#)

We wanna collect examples. So we'd love to talk to you about any experiences you had in Founder Mode in the history of Benchling. But we first wanna hear what is Benchling for our listeners.

Sajith: Sure. So, yeah, I'm I'm the cofounder and CEO of Benchling. We went through the summer twenty twelve Y Combinator batch, and you can think about Benchling as we build modern software for scientific progress. So our customers are biotech are scientists at biotech and pharma companies. It's about 200,000 scientists at 7,000 universities and 1,300, companies making medicines that use Benchling.
[\(00:01:06\)](#)

And our software helps them design their experiments, capture the data, and analyze it and share it with each other. And you wouldn't believe it, but, life science is, making a medicine is an incredibly hard, difficult process. Costs about \$2,500,000,000. Ninety percent of medicines fail when they're in a clinical trial. And the technology that powers this industry is a mix of paper and spreadsheets and emails.

So it's pretty archaic. And so technology is, like, a really important way to improve the success rate and bring more medicines to people faster.

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Jessica: [\(00:02:02\)](#) Wow. My sister works in an industry, and so I am sort of familiar with how expensive and complicated.

Sajith: [\(00:02:08\)](#) It's it's, it's quite easier to put a person on the moon than it is to make a new medicine. Yeah. And there's Literally. Yeah.

Carolynn: [\(00:02:15\)](#) There's, like, four phases of clinical trials too. So it's just like, the whole process is lengthy and expensive. Have you been able to quantify the dollars that your software saves in this \$2,000,000,000 process.

Sajith: [\(00:02:28\)](#) Yeah. That's it's definitely obviously, that's a you know, we'd love for, at the end of the day, for customers to feel like, oh, I buy Benchling. I get my medicines to patients faster. And I think the way we can do that is to down different parts of the problem and how we can we can speed them up. You know, the different parts of the scientific process where we can measure how much actually, science can get done, how many, you know, turns of a certain workflow can get done in a period of time, or how many people are needed to run a certain process.

And so we have ways of breaking down the problem into smaller pieces and showing that they can be done way faster with our technology. Actually, during COVID, there were a couple of the, monoclonal antibodies. But, you know, before we had vaccines, a couple of those antibodies were actually made by companies who did all their science on Benchling and, you know

Jessica: [\(00:03:09\)](#) No way.

Sajith: [\(00:03:10\)](#) Obviously, there wasn't, like, an AB test of one of our, you know, noncustomer not using Benchling versus the one that did. But, they were able to, like, get these things out in record time and, you know, come at you know, there's scientists in the lab who are doing the hard critical work. Those are the people in the trenches, but, like, that plus robotics plus software, Benchling allowed them to go way faster than everyone else.

Jessica: [\(00:03:29\)](#) And how many people are you now? Because you've been around thirteen years.

Sajith: [\(00:03:33\)](#) Long time. We are about 600 people, based in the Bay Area. We have offices in Boston, which is obviously a huge biotech hub and then also in Europe as well.

Carolynn: [\(00:03:41\)](#) 600.

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Sajith: 600 people.
[\(00:03:42\)](#)

Carolynn: Lot. Yeah. Big company.
[\(00:03:42\)](#)

Jessica: So you've been running this from the very beginning when you didn't know anything.
[\(00:03:45\)](#)

Sajith: Didn't know anything about anything.
[\(00:03:50\)](#)

Carolynn: Well, by the way, did you start at y when you did YC in summer twelve, brand spanking new company? Like, you just

Sajith: Brand spanking new company. I was I was a junior at MIT. I studied CS, but I worked in a bunch of bio labs, and it was always weird to me that all the software people, which was one of the crowds I was with, they had great tools for working together. Yeah. And then the bio people had just, again, paper Yeah.

It was crazy to me.

Jessica: Right. I remember we were very excited about that idea. We love when programmers also have, you know, medical kind of knowledge and that kind of thing where they can bridge that gap.

Carolynn: It's a cool crossover.
[\(00:04:25\)](#)

Sajith: Yeah. So YC was the only people who believed at the time.
[\(00:04:26\)](#)

Jessica: Really? Had you been to other No.
[\(00:04:29\)](#)

Sajith: Investors? Even after YC, we were, I feel like I, nowadays, I feel like some of the YC partners all they bring me back to talk to the batches to remind them, it's okay if you're not successful after demo day as long as you stick with it.

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Carolynn: [\(00:04:42\)](#) Oh, well, we should we should quickly touch on that. How what did you what were you able to accomplish by demo day, and how would your fundraise go?

Sajith: [\(00:04:49\)](#) Yeah. We had lots of users at universities using our tools. And, actually, PG gave us really great advice of, you know, it's like, hey. The people who are if they are living and breathing in your software, these are the people who, like, work with biology, like, someday that will, like, be really important if you are the de facto tool for them. And so we had lots of users at universities using their early versions of our software, but we're making no money.

Yeah. And every investor was like, ah, biology, that seems like kind of a small market. And all the biology people were or all the all the biology people were like, oh, this is really cool, but we make drugs. We don't know, like, software. And so we were kind of in this weird place, and we were very lucky.

Like, we took about a 100 meetings. We raised \$6,700 k of money.

Carolynn: [\(00:05:27\)](#) I don't even

Sajith: [\(00:05:27\)](#) I don't even tell our valuation cap to the founders now. They wouldn't believe me. They wouldn't believe me. And that was enough for us to get off the ground, and we stuck with it and eventually built a built a great business out of it.

Jessica: [\(00:05:40\)](#) So over the years, you've grown. You've had to have turned into a manager.

Sajith: [\(00:05:47\)](#) Sometimes. Yeah. Tell

Jessica: [\(00:05:49\)](#) Us a story that you can think of that has to do with when you've had to go into Founder Mode.

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Sajith:
[\(00:05:54\)](#) Yeah. I think, like, to me, founder mode, I sort of think of it synonymously with just having an ownership mentality, and that's the big difference. And so, hopefully, it's not something people at the company also feel like you know, I hope people at the company feel like they can also have that have that in them. Being an owner to me means acting sort of being comfortable operating at a lot of different levels of the business and feeling a lot of personal care over every detail no matter how small. I think, like, as founder, and I'd want my senior leaders also to feel this way of, like, yeah, you're obviously a steward of the company strategy and vision, but you're you're willing to edit copy on the press release.

Or you're gonna want you're gonna notice when the pixel is off in some design, and you're gonna say something about it. And it's kind of, like, anytime you see something that's below your standard and you let it go, you're sort of saying that's okay. And so to me, it's it's that ownership mentality that that represents founder mode to me. And there have been periods of time where I got away from that, and those were the worst parts

Carolynn:
[\(00:06:53\)](#) Of Okay.

Jessica:
[\(00:06:54\)](#) Tell us about one of those times when you felt you were away from that, like, being so detail oriented.

Sajith:
[\(00:07:01\)](#) I think, like, there were there were definitely some periods of faster headcount growth, and I had hired you know, as we've grown, we have hired senior leaders. I think, you know, hiring executives is a kinda controversial topic, especially at this conference. And I've had great executives who have been transformative for the business, and I've had executives who haven't been the right fit. And I think one of the trickiest parts is trying to when you hire a new executive, trying to understand what is something that represents the domain expertise or the unique skills you hired them for and what's the culture of the company. So just to give you a specific example, at a point when we got bigger, there's a period of time where, like, I and senior leadership got kind of disconnected from our customers.

Like, these days, I and even when the company's getting off the ground, I talk to customers, like, every day. Talk some weeks, I talk to ten, fifteen customers. Like, I'm constantly visiting our users, the executives who buy our software. I'm I'm I'm spending a lot of time getting my own ground truth.

Carolynn:
[\(00:07:57\)](#) Mhmm.

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Sajith: [\(00:07:58\)](#) And there's a period of time, though, where kind of I felt like I had a sort of senior leaders who are more focused on kind kinda building a machine that could talk to customers. And I you can, like, from a theoretical sense here, you could say, like, okay. Well, maybe, like, me talking to all these customers by hand was, like, not a scalable thing. And now that we're bigger and trying to, you know, reach this new height, like, it's just not gonna work anymore. So you can kind of rationalize, like, okay.

Like, maybe they don't need to be that close to customers. But the thing is, like, I think people, like, the behavior of the senior leadership reflects, you know, the whole company becomes like that. And so I end up at a point of time where, like, I had, like, multiple layers of people who just, like, didn't talk to customers. And I was like, how can you run our customer facing organizations if you don't talk to customers?

Jessica: [\(00:08:37\)](#) Like Right.

Sajith: [\(00:08:37\)](#) And so, like, that's the kind of thing where it happens slowly and over time. And, like, I learned to sort of assert more of what I expect out of senior leaders and kind of dictate the cultural standards when earlier, I think I was confused for, oh, this must be just how you do things when you get big. Like, you have teams of people who do that for you, and I was totally wrong.

Carolynn: [\(00:08:55\)](#) Was there, like, a day where you're like, you know what? This needs to stop today. Like, today, I'm gonna go to these senior leaders and be like, we're talking to customers again, boots on the ground. Like, do you was that, like, a moment in time?

Jessica: [\(00:09:06\)](#) I was wondering the same thing.

Sajith: [\(00:09:07\)](#) Oh, I definitely I think there were many moments where on the inside, I was going, oh, shit. Like, this is not good. But you when you when you hire senior leader, you'd you run these long searches. You've had a rigorous process. You've done all the references.

And, like, you kinda know in thirty to sixty days if they're gonna work. And I think the worst part is, you know, I think in these situations, I didn't act fast enough and just probably lying to myself of, like, oh, I just need to, like, coach them, and I'll be able to steer them the right way and so forth. That's not to say they were bad executives or something. I think people replicate the behaviors that made them successful at their past company, and you have to be the judge of, do you need those behaviors at your company?

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Jessica:
[\(00:09:43\)](#)

Right. Right.

Sajith:
[\(00:09:45\)](#)

So I had many, oh, shit moments. I unfortunately didn't do anything about them fast enough.

Carolynn:
[\(00:09:50\)](#)

Inertia's powerful.

Jessica:
[\(00:09:51\)](#)

Yeah. I think that that's one of the biggest lessons that people who are at sort of later stages in their company, can learn, which is people don't act quickly enough to address problems.

Sajith:
[\(00:10:03\)](#)

And by the way, like, I think as founder and CEOs, like, your pro like, people on the ground know what's up. People of company know it's happening.

Carolynn:
[\(00:10:11\)](#)

Yes. Have to assume that

Sajith:
[\(00:10:13\)](#)

The bad news is all people have figured it out down there, and, like, you need to go find the ground truth and get it from them sometimes. Like, you can get a little bit isolated from that.

Jessica:
[\(00:10:21\)](#)

So everyone else many layers

Sajith:
[\(00:10:22\)](#)

Of management. Layers. Like, everyone knows when that's happening. You're often the last one to find out.

Carolynn:
[\(00:10:27\)](#)

So do you think Benchling right now, do you would you call it a flat org? Because that's a pretty dramatic word.

Sajith:
[\(00:10:32\)](#)

Yeah. We're we're definitely not flat. We have layers. I have senior leaders. I think it's much more that I'm I'm way more comfortable trusting my gut on what I expect a senior leader to do.

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And versus I'm I'm a lot less willing to accept just this is how it's been done before. This is how I've done it. And, like, sometimes I will, but I'm gonna be much more comfortable asking why about five times to, like, really understand. And there's some stuff that's nonnegotiables for me. Like, if you're gonna be a senior executive, like, you gotta talk to customers.

And, like, that's just my way of being, and I'm okay with that.

Jessica: And how do you gauge if they're actually talking to customers?
[\(00:11:01\)](#)

Sajith: You have to be able to model the behavior yourself, obviously. It's like I'm I'm talking to customers all the time. When I run my staff meeting, my weekly updates are always involving things I learn from customers. So, like, I should be learning from my senior leaders about their customer interactions just like they should be learning from mine. So I think it's hard to ask for a behavior you're not willing to model.

And I could totally believe for another type of business where maybe you have, like, a million customers or consumer business and everything's, like, statistics, like, I could totally believe you don't have to do that, but we have 1,300 paying industry customers. And some of them are, like, really big. And, like, I know the names of the people who signed their orders on the contract, the admins who I know what their kids' names are. Like, it's, like, it's it's a it's very, very specific.

Carolynn: Sounds very Ronco to Yes. That's from the Ronco playbook. Yeah. I don't Sounds effective, though. Clearly effective.
[\(00:11:43\)](#)

Sajith: I don't ask them to do anything I wouldn't do.
[\(00:11:51\)](#)

Jessica: So Yeah. And maybe that's that's one of the best takeaways is don't ask people to do anything you're not willing
[\(00:11:53\)](#)

Sajith: To do.
[\(00:11:59\)](#)

Carolynn: Or that you don't know how to do because you really should know how every part of your company runs.
[\(00:11:59\)](#)

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Sajith:
[\(00:12:04\)](#) I try. Yeah. And then I also try not I don't let them tell me not to do things now. Like, that's, again, a oh, you shouldn't be doing that, or, like, we have people teams who can do that for you. Like, I think it's that's a place where I don't want any sort of someone coming in from the outside to change how I wanna run the company.

Jessica:
[\(00:12:19\)](#) So do you think over the years, you've just developed more confidence in your own intuition and confidence in pushing back if someone's not doing sort of something the way you want?

Sajith:
[\(00:12:30\)](#) I think so. I'm still not I've you know, I'm not a super conflict happy person. I think it's, like, a learned skill to be, like, ready for conflict. And Yeah. Actually, the first couple executives who hired the company were, like, really great and helped kinda take us, you know, to a different level.

And so as a result, I was a little spoiled that when I got my sort of next management team at some point, like, I wasn't I wasn't used to sort of people who, might come in with a different playbook than, you know, what be required to take us forward. So

Jessica:
[\(00:12:59\)](#) Well, awesome. This was really interesting. Thank you so much for sharing your story with us, and we look forward to having you come back someday for full episodes.

Carolynn:
[\(00:13:09\)](#) A deep dive. A Benchling deep dive. Benchling deep dive.

Sajith:
[\(00:13:12\)](#) Thank you.

Jessica:
[\(00:13:13\)](#) Bye.